SPECTRALFORGE: A PHYSICS-BASED SIMULATOR FOR FLUORESCENCE HYPERSPECTRAL IMAGING

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ABSTRACT

Acquiring four-dimensional fluorescence hyperspectral data is slow and costly. An instrument records a full emission spectrum at each of several excitation wavelengths and for every pixel, fluorescence signals are weak and easily buried in scatter and autofluorescence, and the illumination needed to raise them photobleaches the sample, so a single cube can consume hours of scarce instrument time. This makes it hard to plan acquisitions, prototype processing methods, or build shared benchmarks. We present **SpectralForge**, an open, physics-based simulator that renders realistic 4D excitation-emission cubes with perfect ground truth from a parametric fluorophore model obeying the standard laws of fluorescence photophysics (Kasha, Vavilov, Franck-Condon, Stokes shift), with optional inner-filter attenuation, reabsorption, Foerster resonance energy transfer (FRET), scatter, photon and read noise, and instrument clutter. Because every rendered cube comes with its concentration maps and true emission peaks, a method can be developed, tested, and compared before any measurement is taken. As one worked example, we use the simulator to study spectral band selection, where the goal is to keep only the informative bands and so acquire or process less. Scenes are built so that band variance is decoupled from class informativeness (measured correlation ≈ -0.1), so the task is not solved by variance ranking, and two controls, a random baseline and the full spectrum, tell a real gain from a chance one. Fitting the model to measured drop and collagen spectra tests it against real data, and running a panel of selectors through the simulator shows it behaving as designed and marks where label-free selection helps and where it does not. SpectralForge and its workbench are in active development, with early access available to interested labs on request; the full study is released for reproducible use in 4D fluorescence imaging.

***Index Terms*—** fluorescence hyperspectral imaging, physics-based simulation, synthetic data, excitation-emission, photophysics, band selection.

1. INTRODUCTION

A multi-excitation fluorescence measurement illuminates a sample at several excitation wavelengths and, for each, records an emission spectrum. Every pixel therefore carries an excitation-emission matrix (EEM), and an image is a four-dimensional array over excitation, emission, height, and width (Fig. 1). Fluorophores, tissue states, and species separate in this joint domain, which is why it is used for biomedical and material imaging, for example label-free imaging of cardiac tissue by its endogenous autofluorescence [9,10]. Added excitations separate overlapping fluorophores that a single-excitation image cannot, improving tissue and material classification [12–14], but each one multiplies the acquisition by a full emission scan, signals are weak against scatter and autofluorescence, and the illumination photobleaches the sample. A single 4D cube can consume hours of instrument time, and labeled real cubes remain scarce.

Planning an acquisition, prototyping a processing method, or comparing algorithms all ideally happen before instrument time is committed, yet each needs representative data, and real cubes carry no ground truth about which fluorophores are where or which bands matter. A physically realistic simulator that renders cubes from the laws of fluorescence and returns the underlying concentrations and emission peaks addresses both problems: a method can be built, tested, and benchmarked against an answer key, and only the promising design need reach the instrument.

This paper presents **SpectralForge**, an open simulator of that kind for 4D fluorescence imaging, with an interactive workbench for building scenes by hand and a small library for scripting them. To show the tool at work we take one concrete task, spectral band selection, and run a study through it end to end: the simulator provides the cubes and their ground truth, a controlled evaluation protocol scores the candidate selectors, and the results show both that the tool behaves as designed and where a learned selector actually helps. Band selection is only one use; the same generator supports experiment planning, prototyping, and teaching.

2. THE SPECTRALFORGE FORWARD MODEL

2.1. Photophysics

The generator is built on the physics of fluorescence [1,3] so that "informative" means what it means physically. A fluorophore absorbs a photon, relaxes non-radiatively to the lowest vibrational level of the first excited singlet, and emits (the Jabłoński picture [5]). Four consequences shape the EEM. By *Kasha's rule* [2] emission occurs from that lowest level regardless of the excitation, so the emission shape is independent of excitation wavelength and the EEM is approximately trilinear (an excitation profile times an emission profile times a concentration map), the basis of PARAFAC [4]. By *Vavilov's rule* the quantum yield is, to first order, independent of excitation; only the amount absorbed changes. The *Franck-Condon* principle sets the broadened, roughly mirror-image band envelopes and an optional vibronic shoulder about $1300\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$ to the red. The *Stokes shift* red-shifts emission relative to absorption.

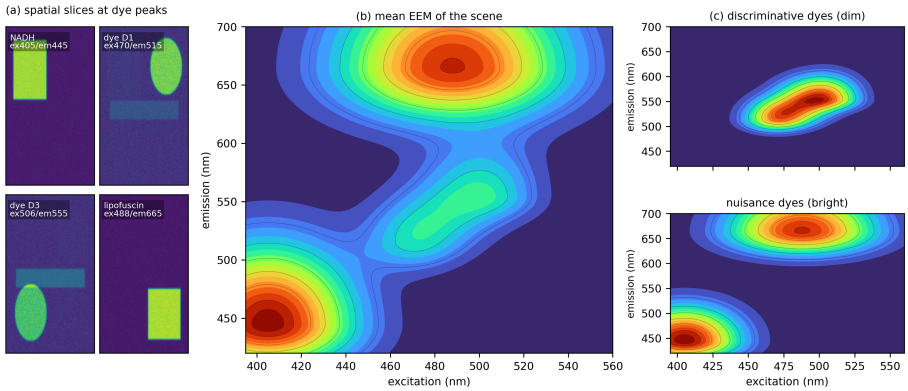


Fig. 1. A rendered 4D fluorescence cube from SpectralForge, an example scene with each dye laid down as a shape. (a) Slices at each dye's emission peak reveal its painted region; every pixel effectively stores an EEM. (b) The mean EEM: each fluorophore is a smooth blob at its excitation and (Stokes-shifted) emission. (c) By role, the discriminative dyes form one dim, overlapping cluster while the class-irrelevant nuisance dyes are bright and well separated, so band variance is dominated by uninformative signal.

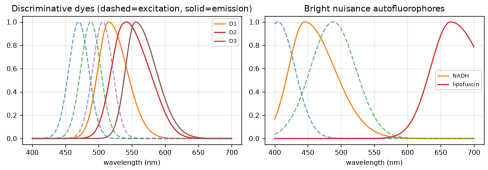


Fig. 2. Parametric fluorophore spectra. Left: three discriminative dyes (dashed, excitation; solid, emission) of modest brightness with overlapping emission and distinct excitation. Right: two bright nuisance autofluorophores that dominate band variance but carry no class information.

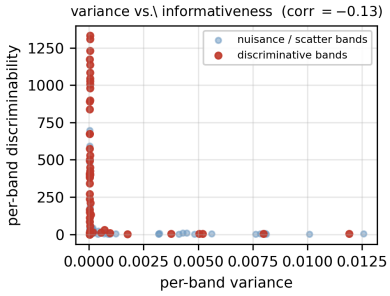


Fig. 3. Variance is decoupled from informativeness. Each point is a band: per-band variance against per-band discriminability. The high-variance bands are nuisance and scatter bands, not the discriminative ones (correlation near zero), so ranking bands by variance fails.

2.2. Trilinear render and the additive invariant

Each fluorophore k is a parametric model with a peak-normalized Gaussian excitation profile $a_k(\lambda_{\mathrm{ex}})$ and an area-normalized emission profile $e_k(\lambda_{\mathrm{em}})$, extinction ε_k, quantum yield Φ_k, and a per-pixel concentration map $c_k(x, y)$. The rendered cube is a dilute linear superposition,

$$F(x, y, \lambda_{\mathrm{ex}}, \lambda_{\mathrm{em}}) = g \sum_k c_k(x, y)\, \varepsilon_k\, \Phi_k\, a_k(\lambda_{\mathrm{ex}})\, e_k(\lambda_{\mathrm{em}}), \quad (1)$$

where g folds lamp, exposure, and power. This is Kasha's rule written as algebra; widths are $\mathrm{FWHM}/(2\sqrt{2\ln 2})$ and brightness is $\varepsilon_k \Phi_k$. With all optional physics and artifacts off the model is *exactly linear*, $\mathrm{render}(A{+}B) = \mathrm{render}(A){+}\mathrm{render}(B)$, an invariant the implementation tests; difficulty is then added in realistic, opt-in increments. A per-pixel class label is the argmax over the discriminative fluorophores. Fig. 2 shows the fluorophore model.

2.3. Variance is decoupled from informativeness

The central design choice is the scene generator. Discriminative dyes are painted with smooth random concentration fields whose per-pixel argmax defines the class; they are dim and spectrally overlapping, so their content lives in low-variance band *shape*, while independent nuisance dyes are bright but class-irrelevant (Fig. 1c). Scatter ridges, bright autofluorescence, and shot noise add further high-variance but class-irrelevant signal. On a confounded scene the correlation between per-band variance and per-band discriminability is ≈ -0.1, versus strongly positive on naive clean data, so the highest-variance bands carry no class information (Fig. 3) and a variance ranker cannot solve the task.

2.4. Artifacts, nonlinear physics, and clutter

On top of the clean cube the generator adds Rayleigh scatter at $\lambda_{\mathrm{em}} = \lambda_{\mathrm{ex}}$ (with a second-order ghost at $2\lambda_{\mathrm{ex}}$) and a water Raman line at a fixed wavenumber offset ($\approx 3400\,\mathrm{cm}^{-1}$), each scaled by a per-pixel turbidity field, then Poisson shot noise and Gaussian read noise. Three optional effects introduce concentration nonlinearity: a primary inner filter $\exp(-s_{\mathrm{ie}} A_{\mathrm{ex}})$; *reabsorption* $\exp(-s_{\mathrm{re}} A_{\mathrm{em}}(\lambda))$, whose overlap with the blue edge of emission reshapes the band and relocates discriminative information into band shape; and FRET, where a saturating fraction $E = kc_A/(1 + kc_A)$ of donor energy is transferred to a co-localized acceptor, encoding dye co-localization in a band ratio. Compactly, the attenuated signal and the transfer efficiency are

$$F_{\mathrm{obs}} = F\, e^{-s_{\mathrm{ie}} A_{\mathrm{ex}}}\, e^{-s_{\mathrm{re}} A_{\mathrm{em}}(\lambda_{\mathrm{em}})}, \qquad E = \frac{k\, c_A}{1 + k\, c_A}, \quad (2)$$

with $A_{\mathrm{ex}} = \sum_k \varepsilon_k c_k a_k(\lambda_{\mathrm{ex}})$, dimensionless strength knobs $s_{\mathrm{ie}}, s_{\mathrm{re}}$ (not physical path lengths), reabsorption $A_{\mathrm{em}}(\lambda) = \sum_k \varepsilon_k c_k\, a_k(\lambda)$ (the excitation profile serves as absorption profile at the emission wavelength), and a Raman line at $1/\lambda_R = 1/\lambda_{\mathrm{ex}} - \Delta\bar{\nu}$. Finally, fixed-pattern clutter injects many class-irrelevant low-rank spatial fields on random band subsets, the analogue of illumination and detector artifacts and the dominant real-instrument confound. By dialing these knobs the generator spans *clean* (variance ≈ informativeness, an idealized baseline that real acquisitions never meet), *realistic*, *clutter*, *nonlinear* (reabsorption or FRET), and *spatial-texture* regimes from a single call.

2.5. Ground truth, reproducibility, and real fluorophores

Every render returns a ground-truth sidecar with concentration maps, clean cubes, and per-fluorophore emission peaks, which enables a tight *peak-recovery* metric (did a selected band land within a tolerance of a true emission peak; a random selector scores about 0.33) in addition to information-retention metrics. The library's `render` call exposes explicit knobs for size, emission sampling, nuisance brightness, scatter, noise, clutter, and nonlinear physics; the study scripts (`build_dataset` in `reports/`, not part of the library) build each scene and record exact parameters. Parametric dyes can be replaced by measured spectra from a downloaded FPbase payload via a library importer (not yet exposed in the workbench). The in-development 3D workbench, SpectralForge Studio (Fig. 4), lets a user define fluorophores and materials, place a lamp, camera, and samples in a 3D scene, preview the camera's view, render the 4D cube, and inspect it against ground truth.

2.6. Validation against real acquisitions

We fitted Eq. (1), projected through a model of our instrument (a tunable lamp and a Nuance LCTF camera, bands from 420 nm [12]), to measured excitation-emission data. For 16 fluorescent drops, whose dyes are not recorded and so are fitted rather than taken from a library, eight parameters were calibrated at 310/340/385/415 nm; emission at held-out 325/365/400 nm was predicted with no gain refit (median $R^2 = 0.96$, IQR 0.95–0.96; SAM 6.0°; peak error $\approx 17\%$, Fig. 5a). Collagen needed a smooth throughput correction, and its intensities are not comparable across excitations (an unexplained $\approx 1000\times$ gain step between 340 and 365 nm), so only emission shape was tested: held-out SAM was $8.4 \pm 1.8^\circ$ (nominal twin 14.2°, flat 23.7°), slightly worse than copying another sample's spectrum (7.7°; Fig. 5b).

3. EVALUATION PROTOCOL

Two questions must be kept apart. (a) *Is the simulator physically faithful?* This is covered by the linearity invariant tests of Sec. 2.2 and by the real-data check of Sec. 2.6. (b) *Is the benchmark valid for comparing selectors?* This is covered by the known ground truth together with the random and full-spectrum controls below, which need no claim that any single simulated cube equals a real one. Table 1 summarizes the whole setup.

3.1. Spectral grid

The simulator accepts an arbitrary excitation list and emission range and step. The reported study uses 4 excitations (405, 470, 488, 506 nm) and emission from 420 to 700 nm. For Fig. 6, emission is sampled every 2 nm (141 bands), giving $4 \times 141 = 564$ excitation-emission bands; "full-564" is the classifier on all of them and the "number of selected bands" (up to 100) is a subset of these. For Table 2 the step is 5 nm (57 bands, 228 features).

Table 1. Experimental setup and the reason for each element.

Element	Setting	Why
Selectors	variance; PCA loadings; AE latent perturbation (label-free); mutual information (uses labels)	naive, linear, learned, and supervised-reference baselines
Regimes	clean; realistic; clutter; reabsorption; FRET; spatial-texture	ideal baseline; scatter and noise; fixed-pattern artifacts; nonlinear shape; co-localization; spatial-only class
Noise (Fig. 6 left)	5 levels, pristine to severe (photon scale $5{\times}10^4$ to 200, Rayleigh 0.1 to 0.7, clutter amplitude 0 to 4.5)	does a gain survive degradation
Classifiers	k-NN, RF, MLP, LR (Fig. 6: first three); macro-F1; cross-validated, spatial-block CV for spatial texture	selection scored by downstream use, not reconstruction
Controls	random subsets (95th percentile); full spectrum	chance gain; accuracy ceiling
Seeds	6 (Table 2), 2 (Fig. 6 left, middle), 3 (spatial texture)	variability, paired CIs
Scene, grid	$64{\times}64$ px (Table 2: $40{\times}40$), 3 classes; 564 bands (Fig. 6) or 228 (Table 2), Sec. 3.1	known labels and peaks

Selection quality is the accuracy of a downstream classifier on the selected bands, with labels used only at evaluation time. We score each subset with a classifier panel (k-nearest neighbors, random forest, MLP, logistic regression), cross-validated, reporting macro-F1 and, on nonlinear regimes, a *nonlinear-only gap* (the accuracy an expressive model recovers beyond a linear one), because a linear metric cannot credit a nonlinear-shape selection. Two controls matter here. A **random** baseline: a method that cannot beat the 95th percentile of random band subsets adds nothing. And the **full spectrum**: the accuracy ceiling a selector tries to approach. Where discrimination is spatial we use spatial-block cross-validation to remove spatial-autocorrelation leakage. These controls guard against reporting a gain that a random subset already reaches.

4. USING THE BENCHMARK

Band selection, which removes non-informative bands to shrink a real hyperspectral acquisition [8, 11, 15], is one thing SpectralForge is built to test, so we exercise it with a panel of standard selectors: variance ranking, PCA loadings [7], supervised mutual information (a labels-using reference), and a fully unsupervised autoencoder [6]-with-latent-perturbation selector, which reconstructs the standardized cube, perturbs each latent dimension, and turns the per-band reconstruction sensitivity into a per-band influence. The question is not which selector wins but whether the benchmark behaves as designed, that is, whether decoupling variance from informativeness makes it discriminate methods and regimes.

It does. On confounded scenes a variance ranker does no better than, and usually below, random subsets (e.g. 0.40 vs 0.45 on the realistic regime). PCA loadings is the strongest blind selector only in the idealized *clean* regime, where the informative bands

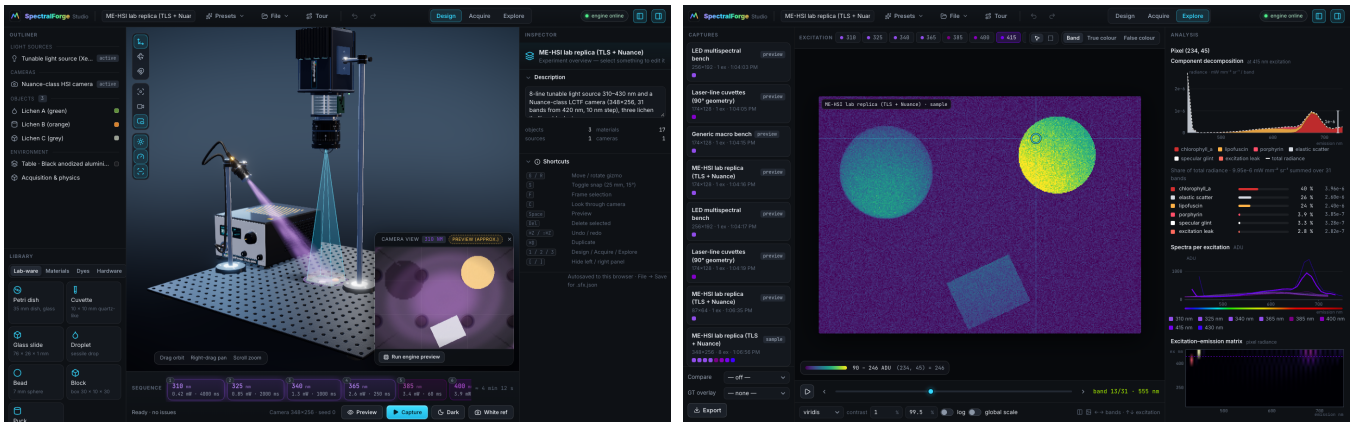


Fig. 4. SpectralForge Studio, the in-development 3D workbench. (a) Design: the user places a tunable lamp, an LCTF hyperspectral camera, and lichen samples in 3D, sets the excitation sequence, and previews the camera's view. (b) Explore: a rendered band image of the 4D cube with, for the selected pixel, the ground-truth decomposition into physical components (chlorophyll, lipofuscin, porphyrin, scatter, glint, leak), spectra per excitation, and the pixel EEM. The band-selection study below used the core generator of Sec. 2, not Studio's added physics.

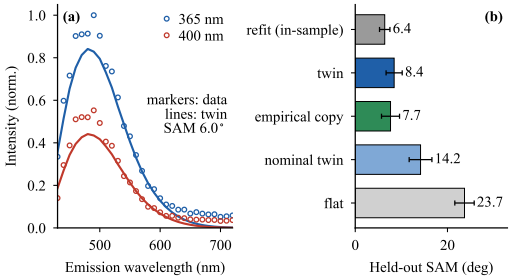


Fig. 5. Real-data validation. (a) Drop 5 (median SAM): measured emission and twin prediction at held-out excitations. (b) Collagen held-out-excitation SAM, mean ± SD over 24 splits (pepsin and acetic-acid ROIs).

are also the brightest. No real fluorescence acquisition reaches that regime, since real cubes always carry scatter, autofluorescence, and noise; once those enter, on the realistic and FRET regimes, the two selectors tie. Label-free selection marginally overtakes PCA only where the physics places discriminative information in nonlinear band *shape*, as under reabsorption (macro-F1 0.449 vs 0.431, bootstrap 95% CI $[+0.001, +0.029]$, Cohen $d \approx +0.94$, but paired Wilcoxon $p = 0.16$, so the gain is marginal; the AE-MLP subset carries nonlinear-only information $+0.014$, the conv-AE -0.001, against -0.016 for PCA loadings; Table 2). The pattern is a general one: *informative implies has variance implies PCA-selectable*, so a nonlinear *classification* task need not imply a nonlinear *selection* task, and the benchmark separates the two. This regime map, not a single winner, is what the benchmark reports.

The random and full-spectrum controls also mark the limits (Fig. 6). Under fixed-pattern clutter no blind selector beats a random subset, because clutter is high-variance but class-irrelevant; there only label-aware selection helps. No selector beats the full spectrum, so selection buys compression, not accuracy, and blind subsets are unstable band to band (Jaccard about 0.1 to 0.2), which favors selecting spectral regions or consensus sets. And when class is carried by spatial texture, so that every class shares the same

Table 2. Label-free autoencoder vs. the strongest blind baseline (PCA loadings): best-of-panel macro-F1 over six seeds. Bold marks the better selector. The clean margin is significant (paired Wilcoxon $p = 0.03$); for reabsorption the bootstrap 95% CI excludes zero but $p = 0.16$, so it is marginal; the rest are ties.

Regime	AE	PCA-load	verdict
clean	0.590	**0.635**	linear suffices
realistic	0.527	0.531	tie
reabsorption	**0.449**	0.431	marginal AE gain
FRET	0.635	0.642	tie

per-pixel spectrum, per-pixel selection falls below random (three seeds, 0.52 against a random 0.71), the oracle bands reach 0.75, and none of the spatial selectors we tried (texture variance or MI, 0.66 to 0.69; a spatial CNN, 0.53 in a separate finer configuration with random 0.58) beats random, so spatial selection remains open. The benchmark thus shows when to select bands, when to keep the spectrum, and when the problem is spatial.

5. DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

SpectralForge gives 4D fluorescence imaging an open, physically realistic source of cubes with perfect ground truth, so methods can be tested before scarce instrument time is spent. The band-selection study is one demonstration. With random and full-spectrum controls, the simulator turns "does this selector help" into a measured, reproducible question, and its answer is specific: PCA loadings is the strongest blind baseline only in the idealized clean regime that no real acquisition reaches, ties label-free selection once realistic scatter and noise enter, and is only marginally overtaken where the physics is nonlinear.

While SpectralForge captures key primary photophysical phenomena, the simulator operates under certain physical and optical simplifications. Currently, inner-filter attenuation and reabsorption are modeled using first-order exponential path approximations rather than full 3D radiative transfer or Monte Carlo photon transport through dense scattering media. Furthermore, the instrument

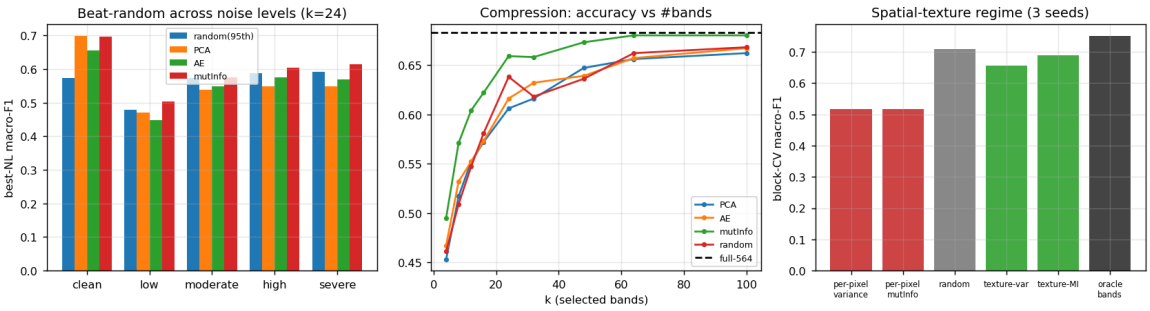


Fig. 6. The benchmark in use. Left: beat-random across five noise levels at a budget of $k = 24$ of the 564 bands (Sec. 3.1): blind PCA and autoencoder selection beat the random 95th percentile only on clean data, and under clutter only supervised mutual information does. Middle: compression curve over budgets of 4 to 100 of the 564 bands: the autoencoder tracks PCA at every budget, both reaching about 95% of the full spectrum, while labels compress about 2.7× better. Right: the spatial-texture regime under block cross-validation: per-pixel selectors are the worst (below random) because the classes have identical per-pixel spectra, and none of the learned spatial selectors beats random; only the known discriminative bands reach the oracle.

model assumes an idealized optical train with spatially uniform illumination, uniform spectral detector response, and static photophysics, omitting dynamic exposure photobleaching kinetics during sequence acquisition as well as chromatic aberrations and thermal drift. Expanding the engine to incorporate full radiative transport and dynamic bleaching models remains an important direction for future extensions; the in-development workbench (Fig. 4) already adds 3D Monte Carlo transport and acquisition-order photobleaching, which future versions of the benchmark will use.

A natural next step is to evaluate performance on complex, multi-component target samples (heterogeneous biological tissues, environmental specimens, or engineered multi-fluorophore composites), where informative spectral structure is decoupled from overall band variance. SpectralForge and its workbench are in active development toward a production release, and the authors can provide exclusive early access to interested laboratories and individuals on request (please contact the corresponding author by email); the full experiment record accompanying this study is released for reproducible use.

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